



NIGERIA FROM INDEPENDENCE TO THE NIGERIA CIVIL WAR

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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

At the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Discuss the events after Nigeria's independence.
- Explain the political intrigues, economic development and military intervention leading to the first and second coup.
- Describe the pogrom and consequently the civil war.



INTRODUCTION

Nigeria achieved independence from British colonial rule on October 1, 1960.

The national question emerged after independence, raising questions like, What is Nigeria? Who are Nigerians? How do we develop a meaningful national identity?

The regional system posed a challenge to national consciousness, and access to national power came from first holding power in the region, which promoted the fear of domination.





NIGERIA AT INDEPENDENCE

The problem of national unity was apparent in the early 1960s.

Efforts were made to bring Nigerians closer politically, economically, and culturally through the promotion of a strong central state and a state-run economy that focused on development.

These efforts failed largely because of events in the political sphere: official corruption, rigged elections, ethnic baiting, bullying, and thuggery dominated the conduct of politics in the First Republic.





ART AND THE NATIONAL QUESTION

In theatre and literature, Nigerians made great contributions to national unity.

Chinua Achebe: *Things Fall Apart* (1958)

Amos Tutuola: *The Palm-Wine Drinkard* (1952)

Wole Soyinka: *A Dance of the Forest* (1960)

The plays and universities had a multi-ethnic make-up, which fostered unity.





ART AND THE NATIONAL QUESTION

Sculptors like Uche Okeke, Susanne Wenger, and Felix Idubor drew inspiration from Nigeria's pre-colonial past and used traditional design motifs.

Despite all of these efforts, the national question could not be solved. Ethnic tensions heightened, culminating in the civil war.





ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

The expansion of formal education was part of the plan for economic development.

The First National Development Plan (FNDP) of 1962–1968 focused on agriculture, industry, and education.

The economy grew at a steady rate between 1960 and 1966.

- Agriculture: 63.4% fell to 55.6 (GNP).
- Manufacturing: 3.6% to 6.2% (GNP)
- Mining: 0.9% to 4.8% (GNP)
- Distribution of goods: 9.1% to 14%
- National income grew at a 5% average.
- Per capita peal increased from \$48.1 million to \$53.8 million.

The military coup of 1966 led to the end of development planning efforts.

THE FIRST NATIONAL DEVELOPMENT PLAN (FNDP, 1962-1968). CONT'D

Achievements of the plan:

- Port Harcourt Refinery,
- The Nigerian Security and Minting Plant,
- the Sugar Mill,
- Niger Dam,
- The Niger Bridge, Onitsha,
- Kaingi Dam and the
- Jebba Paper Mill

However, the plan failed to achieve its too many objectives and also the outbreak of the Nigerian Civil War in 1967 also played a negative role.



THE ROLE OF DEVELOPMENT CORPORATIONS IN ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

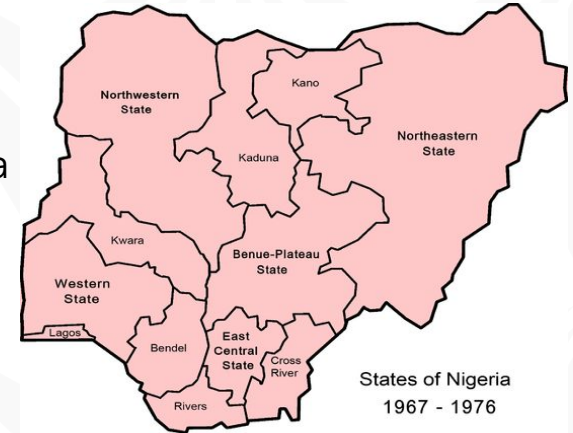
Richard's constitution was the first to introduce regionalism, a system that was adopted during the First Republic.

The regional development corporations were key to the development of their regions.

Western Region - Western Nigeria Development Corporation

Eastern Region - Eastern Nigeria Development Corporation

Northern Nigeria - Northern Nigeria Development Corporation





THE ROLE OF DEVELOPMENT CORPORATIONS IN ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

The regions focused on goods in which they had a comparative advantage.

West – Cocoa, timber, etc.

East – Palm oil, etc.

North – Groundnut, etc.

The regions grew at their own pace.





POP UP QUIZ

What was the significance of Richard's constitution during the First Republic in Nigeria?

- A) It abolished regionalism in Nigeria.
- B) It introduced regionalism, establishing regional development corporations.
- C) It centralized power in the federal government.
- D) It led to the dissolution of the regional governments.



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Richard's constitution marked a pivotal moment in Nigerian history as it introduced the concept of regionalism during the First Republic. Regional development corporations were established in each of the major regions (Western, Eastern, and Northern Nigeria) to promote economic development within those regions. This move was a significant step in decentralizing power and fostering regional autonomy and development.



POLITICS OF THE FIRST REPUBLIC

Political instability characterised Nigeria's First Republic:

- Election of 1959
- Fear of dominance
- Quota system
- Disproportionate project allocation
- Western region crisis
- Creation of the Mid-Western region.
- The census crisis of 1962-3
- 1964 election crisis – UPGA vs NNA
- The Western Region election of 1965

Chart 1: Percentage of Populations
1952-53 Census

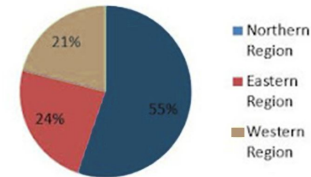
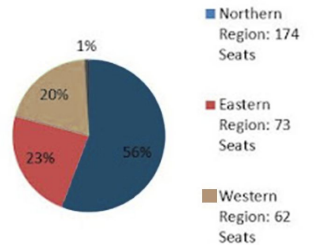


Chart 2: 1959 General Election,
Allocation of seats in Parliament





MILITARY INTERVENTION: FIRST COUP

The coup was launched on January 15, 1966, led by the 'five majors' – Nzeogwu, Ifeajuna, Okafor, Anuforo, and Ademoyega.

The leaders of the coup claimed that tribalism and corruption were the reasons for the coup.

Many coups claimed many lives. Several northern leaders and military officers were killed. A number of notable politicians were also killed in the west, and very few easterners died in that coup.

Many people consider the coup an Igbo coup.

The coup failed as the leaders of the coup could not seize power, and power was devolved to the commanding officer of the army, Major General John Aguiyi-Ironsi.



IRONSI ASCENDANCY RISE POWER

Ironsi's government was poised to restore law and order, maintain essential services, eradicate regionalism and tribalism, and end corruption.

Ironsi appointed military governors to the regions, one of whom was Chukwuemeka Odumegwu Ojukwu, who headed the eastern region.

The coup and Ironsi ascendancy were popular in the south; they were seen as the end of northern dominance.

Ironsi's subsequent policies were seen as a plot for wider Igbo dominance.





IRONSIS' GAFFE

The coup plotters only killed very few easterners; the majority were northerners and some Yorubas.

Ironsi released the coup plotters.

He surrounded himself with Igbo advisers, accelerating the promotion of Igbo officers.

Decree No. 34

Ironsi's policies led northerners to fear domination, which led to a counter coup.



COUNTER COUP

A group of northern NCOs and officers carried out a counter coup on July 29, 1966.

Ironsi was captured and killed in Ibadan.

Lieutenant Colonel Yakubu Gowon was selected as HOS.

Gowon immediately announced the repeal of Decree 34.

Ojukwu and Gowon face off on seniority.

Owing to a number of factors, Igbos were targeted in the north, which led to a pogrom.





THE POGROM

Between 80,000 and 100,000 easterners were massacred in the north. This sparked revenge killings of northerners in the East.

The pogrom led to a mass return of Igbos to the East.

This led to Ojukwu's quest for secession; Gowon was determined to keep the status quo.

This led to negotiations, one of which was the Aburi Accord.

As negotiations failed, Ojukwu declared the East's independence on May 30, 1967, resulting in war.





THE CIVIL WAR

The Nigerian government could not allow Biafra's secession for a number of reasons:

- Believe in the practicability of Nigerian unity.
- Fragmentation of Nigeria into small states
- The prospect of Biafra leaving with oil-producing states

The Nigerian civil war, sometimes called the Biafran War, lasted two and a half years.

Immediately after Ojukwu declared Biafra's independence, Gowon declared a state of emergency and announced the creation of states.





STATE CREATION

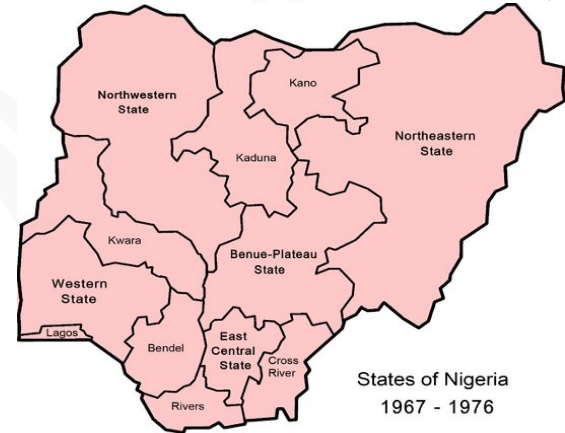
Twelve states were created out of the existing regions.

Three states were carved out of the Eastern region, and only one was predominantly Igbo.

The creation of the state was designed to isolate the Igbos and stiffen the Biafran economy through a series of measures:

- Blockade of the coastline
- Currency change

The twin policy thrust caused malnutrition, inflation, and economic strangulation, which was believed to lead to an internal uprising but instead led to international sympathy and support for Biafra.





INTERNATIONAL INTERVENTION DURING THE WAR

Ojukwu's Biafra used pictures of starving children as proof of genocide, and this propaganda proved effective as some countries began to show support for the Biafran course.

International support helped prolong the war.

- The OAU refused to treat the war as a civil war but rather as a war between two independent nations.
- The US and UK chose to be neutral.
- The USSR supported the FMG and supplied aircraft and advisers.





INTERNATIONAL INTERVENTION DURING THE WAR

- OAU member states, Tanzania, Gabon, Ivory Coast, and Zambia, formally recognised Biafra in 1968.
- International reports of genocide led several European and Asian countries to show solidarity with Biafra.
- France and Portugal provided Biafra with supplies and logistics.
- Israel also shared its sentiments for Biafra.
- China also showed support for Biafra, but with no serious material support.
- The Catholic Church and the International Red Cross provided humanitarian aid to Biafrans.



THE END OF THE WAR

International support helped prolong the war, but by January 1970, Biafra had been overrun by federal troops, leading to its collapse.

Ojukwu eventually fled to Ivory Coast, and Effiong surrendered to Gowon in Lagos on January 12, 1970.





LEGACIES OF THE WAR

The war had taken the lives of up to 3 million Nigerians, leaving another 3 million displaced.

Gowon declared "no winner, no vanquished and that there were "no winners or losers in the war between brothers".

The 3 Rs (reconstruction, reconciliation, and rehabilitation) began swiftly, but the national question continues to plague Nigerian political rhetoric.

This is largely because the 3 R's failed, and the Igbos have continually suffered marginalisation owing to the war to this day.

This has stagnated the Nigerian state; he who holds another man down cannot move himself. In order to understand post-war management, Rwanda provides a working template.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, we have:

- Discussed the events after Nigeria's independence.
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- Described the pogrom and consequently the civil war.



REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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THANK YOU